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President
to begin
official visit
to Russia

ABU DHABI

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan will begin an official visit to the Russian Federation today. During the visit, Sheikh Mohamed will meet with Vladimir Putin, President of Russia, to explore opportunities to strengthen ties, particularly related to the economy, trade, investment, energy, and other sectors that support shared development within the framework of the two countries' strategic partnership. The talks will also cover regional and international issues of mutual interest.

Italian President's visit

The President yesterday held talks with Sergio Mattarella, President of Italy, to discuss opportunities to strengthen bilateral cooperation and the UAE-Italy strategic partnership in line with their shared commitment to promoting prosperity and development for both nations and peoples. The talks were held at Qasr Al Shati in Abu Dhabi.

— WAM
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■ Flames engulf the wreckage of the Learjet 45 after it crashed near Baramati Airport in Pune yesterday.

Maharashtra deputy CM killed
in plane crash amid lapses

Learjet carrying Pawar bursts into flames minutes after aborted landing attempt

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

The fatal plane crash near Baramati Airport that killed Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar and four others unfolded in a swift sequence of missed communication, poor visibility and sudden disaster, according to the Ministry of Civil Aviation. The Learjet 45 aircraft burst into flames barely a minute after being cleared to land yesterday morning, with air traffic controllers receiving no confirmation from the cockpit. Pawar, 66, one of Maharashtra's key power brokers following the 2023 split in the Nationalist Congress Party, was travelling in the private chartered aircraft from Mumbai to Baramati, the

100ft
short of the runway
the aircraft plunged
before crashing

family's political stronghold, where he was scheduled to attend public meetings ahead of local body polls. The government said Baramati airport is an "uncontrolled" airfield where traffic coordination relies heavily on pilot communication. The ministry's report said the aircraft first contacted Baramati station at 8:18am and was cleared to descend under visual conditions. The pilots aborted the first landing after failing to spot Runway 11 due to poor visibility. On the second approach, the crew reported the runway in sight and were cleared to land at 8:43am but failed to give the mandatory readback confirm-

ing clearance. A minute later, flames were seen near the runway threshold. The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau has taken over the probe. Witnesses described terrifying moments as the aircraft appeared to lose control seconds before touchdown, plunging nearly 100 feet short of the runway before crashing and exploding. "I saw it crash and burst into flames. There were several explosions," a witness told ANI. Prime Minister Narendra Modi described Pawar's death as "shocking and saddening", calling him a grassroots leader. Pawar, nephew of NCP founder Sharad Pawar and cousin of MP Supriya Sule, is survived by his wife Sunetra and sons Parth and Jay. "There's no conspiracy involved; it's purely an accident. Maharashtra has suffered a huge loss. Maharashtra has lost a great personality today. This loss can never be compensated," Sharad Pawar said.

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Emirates to hire
20,000 new staff,
add 38 lounges

RECRUITMENT, ENHANCEMENT LINKED TO AGGRESSIVE AIRCRAFT DELIVERIES

DUBAI

BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

Dubai's Emirates is gearing up for major transformation by the end of the decade, with plans to recruit nearly 20,000 operational staff while launching dozens of new lounges globally this year itself. Adel Al Redha, deputy president and chief operations officer, revealed the expansion roadmap during a media roundtable in Dubai yesterday.

Hiring drive ahead

Recruitment will span operational roles such as cabin crew, pilots, engineers, technicians and airport staff as the airline receives more aircraft and expands its network. "We continue to hire to meet our needs as we will receive more aircraft, which will be deployed to new destinations or current routes to increase frequency," Al Redha said. He said that the airline has specific programmes for UAE nationals, with current capacity to train about 120 per year for cabin crew and engineering. "We have a plan to increase this number in the years to come," Al Redha said. The recruitment links to aggressive aircraft deliveries.

Separate recruitment drive

There will be a separate recruitment drive in future for a seat manufacturing unit in Dubai, a joint venture in the pipeline between Emirates and Safran.



Emirates is equipping 150 aircraft with free Starlink Wi-Fi by the end of 2026. The rollout began with 10 Boeing 777s now fitted with the satellite-based service.

Al Redha confirmed that Emirates continues to see high demand across its entire network, despite regional tensions causing some European airlines to reduce Middle East operations. Emirates is also enhancing catering, onboard accessories and ground facilities. According to Al Redha, the airline expects 38 dedicated lounges globally for premium passengers by this year end.

Free Wi-Fi rollout

Meanwhile, Emirates is equipping 150 aircraft with free Starlink Wi-Fi by the end of 2026. The rollout began with 10 Boeing 777s now fitted with the satellite-based service, Al Redha said. "The feedback from passengers using the Wi-Fi connectivity has been very positive," Al Redha noted. This represents a step towards retrofitting the entire 232-strong fleet by mid-2027. He also addressed a burning question in the minds of several aviation enthusiasts: whether iconic first-class shower spas would feature on new Boeing 777X aircraft expected in 2027.

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TELL ME WHY

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A quieter, eco-friendly journey in UAE

DUBAI

BY SURABHI
VASUNDHARADEVI
Social Media Reporter



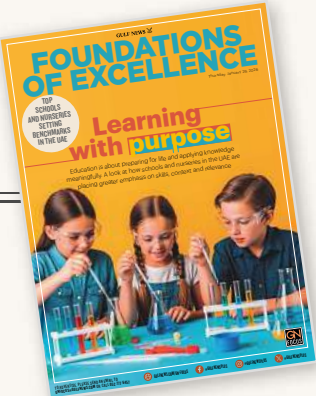
The future of transport in the UAE just got a serious magnetic upgrade. Etihad Rail has officially pulled back the curtain on a groundbreaking partnership with IronLev, a high-tech Italian pioneer, to launch the region's first-ever magnetic levitation (maglev) trial. This isn't just a fancy science experiment; it's a bold vision

for how we'll move goods and people across the UAE with virtually zero friction. Unlike traditional maglev systems that require power-hungry tracks, this trial uses permanent magnets to lift the train above existing rails without needing a constant stream of electricity just to stay afloat.

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and nurseries

ENTERTAINMENT

'My Emmy is in a cabinet, wrapped in thermals' | P14



IN FOCUS

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